The Chambers of a Gun if the Bullet Does Not Exist

By Zanne Langlois and Natasha Hooper

INTRODUCTION

*Sometimes complex processes are easier to understand when you break them down into their component parts. Take America's uncomfortable marriage to gun violence for example – Let's look at the numbers for one day only. Just one day. As families and communities rang in the New Year in 2025, there were more than 200 shootings across the country -- a total of 78 people were killed and another 197 people were injured.**

The Chambers of a Gun by Zanne Langlois breaks gun violence down in another way -- address the political and public systems that fail to prevent these tragedies. Inaction in the face of tragedy. Thoughts and prayers but let's stop there.

The Chambers of a Gun by Zanne Langlois

A gun has 26 working parts-

The length of the barrel, the speed of the bullet,

And caliber of the ammunition determines lethality.

There are 6 chambers in the cylinder.

When cocked, the hammer clicks, as it locks into place.

The trigger requires a precise amount of pressure to fire.

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The target erupts, as the bullet forces entry,

Opening a door that cannot be closed.

An act that cannot be undone.

A school shooting has countless working parts.

The lengths at which the shooter will go to force entry.

The speed of the response and the caliber of the security system

Determine its lethality.

The first shot triggers a lock-down.

The fire alarm sounds as chaos erupts

And classrooms become as deadly and inescapable

As gas chambers.

The shooter burns through clips of bullets,

Until police, moving with precision, secure the building.

Reopening closed doors, separating the student body

Into living and dead.

The Senate has 100 working parts.

The size of the majority, the length of their terms,

And the caliber of the lobbyists determine its productivity.

The massacre of school children triggers debate in the chamber.

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But while the men and women are dead-locked,
Arguing endlessly behind closed doors,
Two pressure cookers erupt in Boston.
And new images of carnage force entry into our minds.
We barely notice when the Senate body rejects gun control.

The American electorate has 200 million working parts.
The size of the tragedy, the length of the media coverage,
And the caliber of the press photographers determines the
level of outrage.
Pressure builds and erupts in shocked headlines,
But the firing squad has no trigger to pull.
The shooter's last bullet forced entry to his skull,
Closing the door to why and leaving only what,
And how, and this is not a question we want to answer.
The four chambers of a human heart
Are each filled with separate desires.
For safety, for freedom, for power, for protection.
We are dead-locked. And minds that are closed cannot be
re-opened.

But a murdered child has no working parts.
Its body does not function.

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The size of the child at the time of its death determines
The length of a coffin.
A coffin is a chamber lined with silk and sorrow.
When the lid clicks shut, it cannot be re-opened.
When will this trigger more than tears?
When will we feel the pressure of small hands
Hammering on the locked doors or our hearts?
As soon as our eyes are dry, we shut them again.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Zanne Langlois
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https://mrsconnollysclass.com/wp-content/uploads/2021/01/chambers-of-a-gun-zanne-langlois.pdf
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AWARD HISTORY

2023 National Qualifier – MS (this poem only)
2024 National Qualifier – MS (this poem only)

****Introduction statistic source***
https://www.everytown.org/press/2025-already-marked-by-tragedy-as-gun-violence-devastates-new-years-celebrations-advocates-urge-lawmakers-entering-legislative-sessions-to-pass-stronger-gun-safety-measures/

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TRANSITION

But what if (pause as if seeing someone roll their eyes) I know, but "what if" will get us just as far as "thoughts and prayers" when it comes to gun violence. So, what if guns were symbols of peace rather than destruction? What if joy could replace death? And what if the bullet did not exist? Instead -- only hope, only joy, only triumph, only life. Natasha Hooper reimagines everyday gun use and the possibility of a better future in what she admits may only happen in an alternate universe.

The Bullet Does Not Exist by Natasha Hooper

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In Jacksonville, Florida, a man parks his vehicle at a gas station. With all his angst resting quietly in his glove compartment, he makes his displeasure known next to a car full of black boy joy and turns jubilee into chaos. A teenager is no more by the end of the night while another Friday will be a commemoration in a year's time and we are all left wondering how the gun keeps ending up in the wrong hands.

There is an alternate universe in which the word "gun" is
welcomed
into every conversation.
Where a holster hangs from a hip as brilliantly as a star,

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Waiting to be birthed into the next milky way.
Each gun is handled with a soft grip,
Like a withered petal seconds away from becoming dust.
'Whisper' is etched into the metal of every muzzle and
alas,
The bullet does not exist.
In this universe, we load our guns with bliss.
Pack happiness tightly into each magazine,
And pull the trigger as if it were a sunrise on a Sunday
morning.
We say things like "Remember that shootout at the gas
station?
How the gunman came prepared,
Concealed his dreams in his car like some undiscovered
magic
at the base of an ocean.
Remember how we showed him our carefree
and he showed us his barrel?
Pointed it at all the young and black bodies, repeatedly
pulling the trigger
And the only thing that came out was laughter?"
Each shootout would indeed be a welcomed experience

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with no funerals to follow.
A trip to the gun range would be therapy, a Berreta to
dispense
our tears and a shotgun with only tissues in the barrel.
Tamir would play cops and robbers without imagining
death,
Chyna would walk home with only a compliment on her
back,
Philando would drive away wiping the excess elation off
his shirt,
And all the church members of Charleston would have
just one more thing to sing about.
Yes, the bullet would not exist,
Which would mean that the gun could never
be in the hands of the wrong person.
An empty clip would be celebrated as a selfless act.
"Look at all the joy he gave away today, how he unified
our nation
with each shot, each invisible ray travelling faster
than the speed of sound
to transform any particular body into a better version of
itself."

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There would be so much delight spilled onto the
concrete
that we would lay down just to soak it up.
Draw chalk outlines around our own bodies to save our
places.
This alternate universe exists with no mention of the
term 'justifiable
death', but rather 'inexplicably content'.
This alternate universe exists with the universal
knowledge
that we will not die today from our guns.
That we will not die any day from our guns.
That our bullets will not even exist if they be
synonymous with death.
Only hope,
Only joy,
Only triumph,
Only life,
Only life,
This alternate universe is life-giving, with the safety off
and a fistful of smiles
Rifles poised at the ready with a clip full of possibilities,

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Pointed at anyone ready and willing

To accept it.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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